

The Record of Linji and the Making of Orthodoxy

1. Linji as text and person

Linji Yixuan is remembered as the exemplary master of the Linji lineage. The Linji lu presents sermons, encounters, shouts, and attacks on spiritual dependency. Albert Welter's textual history shows why the work cannot simply be read as a transcript of a ninth-century teacher. Its received shape reflects centuries of compilation and the Song dynasty's construction of Linji orthodoxy.

2. 'Kill the Buddha' rhetoric

Violent iconoclastic phrases are among the most quoted Zen lines and among the easiest to flatten. Their target is dependency on objectified authority: Buddha, patriarch, sacred state, even an idea of Linji. The rhetoric is not a permission slip for literal violence, nor proof that institutions are irrelevant. It works inside a lineage culture that preserves the very teacher telling students not to depend on teachers.

3. The true person without rank

Linji's 'true person without rank' has attracted metaphysical readings as a hidden Self. That is risky. 'Without rank' can instead target the student's investment in fixed identity and status. The phrase operates in a monastic world saturated with ranks. Its negation is intelligible because the institutional category is real. Again, immediacy gains force through the form it negates.

4. Textual strata

If early quotations of Linji differ from the later received record, interpretation should track which layer supports which claim. A doctrine attested only in a later compilation may still be authentically Linji-lineage teaching, but it is not automatically evidence for Linji's lifetime. 'Authentic' therefore has at least three meanings: spoken by the historical person, continuous with a lineage's teaching, or normatively authoritative for later practice.

5. Orthodoxy as retrospective selection

Song lineages competed through genealogies, transmission histories, public monasteries, patronage, and literary collections. To call Linji the source of a dominant lineage is partly to describe a backward projection from that dominance. Later institutional success changes the archive: it determines what is copied, commented on, and remembered. Historiography must correct for survival bias.

6. Argument

(1) A received record is substantially shaped in the Song. (2) The Song Linji faction had reasons to portray its founder as an unsurpassable Tang iconoclast. Therefore (3) the record should be read both for the image of Linji it transmits and for the Song project that required that image. This does not entail that the image is fabricated wholesale; it changes the burden of proof for particular historical claims.

7. Question

Can a lineage be 'invented' and still preserve genuine continuity? Yes, if invention means selective organization of memory rather than creation ex nihilo. The interesting task is to identify the continuities, discontinuities, and institutional incentives instead of using 'invented' as a verdict.

1. Reconstruction

- 1 The received Linji lu is a text with a transmission history, not direct audio from the ninth century.
- 2 Its Song editors inherited a world in which Linji lineage identity had become institutionally important.
- 3 Editorial selection can therefore both preserve earlier materials and shape them toward later orthodoxy.
- 4 Hence a saying's presence in the received record establishes its authority within the later Linji tradition more securely than it establishes verbatim authorship by the historical Linji.

2. First response: the authorial fallacy

One might object: if a passage is attributed to Linji, denying direct authorship simply distrusts the tradition. But the inference 'the text says Linji said p; therefore the historical Linji said p in these words' treats attribution as if it were already the conclusion of source criticism. Compare a medieval biography that puts a polished speech into a founder's mouth. The speech may accurately summarize remembered commitments while remaining a literary construction. Historical caution does not require contempt for the tradition; it requires distinguishing levels of claim.

3. Modes of authority

There are at least two senses of 'Linji's teaching.' Sense 1: views that can be responsibly attributed to the historical Linji using the earliest available evidence. Sense 2: the body of teaching the Linji tradition came to receive, transmit, and perform as Linji's voice. Welter's study makes the second sense impossible to dismiss as mere corruption because it is precisely how orthodoxy was made. The mistake is allowing Sense 2 to answer every question about Sense 1.

4. The test

For a famous saying, ask four questions. (1) What is the earliest recoverable witness? (2) Does the saying's vocabulary fit that stratum? (3) How does the saying function in the literary unit where it appears? (4) What later institutional claim does citing Linji authorize? A saying that survives these questions may still not be a transcript, but our description of what we know becomes much more precise.

5. Two questions

Does historical distance reduce the religious value of a passage? Not necessarily: a later composition may become a central object of practice. Does religious efficacy increase its value as evidence for an earlier event? Also not necessarily. The two evaluations can move independently.

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